

It's your right and sometimes you have to fight for your right. But it's worth it. Remember these two magic words: "**discharged debt.**"

Just so you know, these debt-buying scum use other strategies besides intimidating consumers and exploiting the credit bureau system. Junk debt scammers try to wear down the victim by repeated nuisance phone calls. They send letters that look like they're from responsible collection agencies or law firms. The scammers rely on the fact that creditors often fail to update the bureau when debts have been discharged. They've found a glitch in the system and they are taking advantage.

Another thing the junk debt company does is change the old account number and assign a new one. This is actually good and makes it easy for you. If a new credit or collection company calls you, ask for the account number. If neither the company name nor the account number match anything in your records, and you previously filed bankruptcy, you need to use the magic words "*discharged debt.*" This is a magical way to absolutely eliminate that debt. Poof. Be gone.

Not My Debt!

Sometimes you can hit a different kind of wall trying to solve a problem on your credit report. Let me tell you a story.

A good friend of mine, Kurt, applied for a credit card and was rejected. He was surprised to be rejected because he had an excellent credit history. Kurt went round and round with the credit card company until he was blue in the face. He was informed that his application was being declined because the credit report showed a \$15,000 balance on an American Express account that had never been paid.

Kurt had never, ever, had an American Express account. He made repeated phone calls to tell the credit card company that the debt was not his and never was. He sent letters explaining that he did not owe the \$15,000 to American Express or any other creditor! In reply, he only received standard form letters. Kurt spent months trying to resolve this, and then he had a lawyer friend draft letters as well.

Most of us know that sometimes our letters may go unnoticed, but an attorney's letterhead usually gets someone's attention. Not in this case. Kurt only received more form letters. He truly felt like he was